Week 9 Case: The Donor's Portfolio

You are: a research analyst at a nonprofit donor advisory firm. Your job is to recommend how political donors should allocate their money across GOTV tactics.

Today: April 2026. A major Democratic donor has $500,000 to spend on voter turnout in competitive state legislative races. She wants it to produce the most additional votes possible.

The four tactics

Your team has assembled published effect estimates for four GOTV tactics, drawn from the academic literature:

Tactic	Effect on turnout	95% CI	Cost per contact	Contact rate	Source
Door-to-door canvassing	+2.0 pp	[+1.0, +3.0]	$20/conversation	30%	Green & Gerber meta-analysis
Direct mail	+0.7 pp	[+0.3, +1.1]	$0.60/piece	100%	Gerber et al. 2017 replication
Phone calls	+0.5 pp	[+0.1, +0.9]	$2.00/completed call	25%	Green & Gerber meta-analysis
Text messages	+0.1 pp	[-0.1, +0.3]	$0.08/text	100%	recent SMS studies

The effects are per person you *try* to reach. The costs are per person you actually *reach*. The contact rate is the share of attempts that connect, so canvassers hold a conversation at about 30% of the doors they knock and phone banks reach a live person on about 25% of the numbers they dial. Mail and texts are 100%: you pay to send, and everyone on the list gets one.

The canvassing estimate is from the same literature you saw in Week 5. The mail estimate is from the same replication data as Week 3. These are numbers you already know.

A new study arrives

Two weeks before your deadline, a new field experiment is published. It tested door-to-door canvassing in 2024 competitive state legislative races, the exact setting your donor cares about. The findings:

- **Effect:** +0.8 percentage points (95% CI: [+0.2, +1.4])
- **Cost:** $25 per completed conversation (higher than the older estimates because of inflation and labor costs)
- **Sample size:** 107,000 households (well-powered)

This is a smaller effect than the meta-analytic average (+2.0 pp) and a higher cost. But it's from the closest match to your donor's intended setting.

The decision

How should the donor allocate $500,000 across the four tactics?

Things to think about:

1. At $20 per canvass conversation and +2.0 pp, what is the cost per additional vote for canvassing? At $0.60 per mail piece and +0.7 pp, what is the cost per additional vote for mail? Which is more cost-effective?
2. The new study says canvassing only works at +0.8 pp in the exact setting your donor cares about. Should you use the meta-analytic average (+2.0 pp) or the new study (+0.8 pp)? What does each choice assume?
3. The text message estimate has a confidence interval that includes zero ([-0.1, +0.3]). Does that mean texting doesn't work? Should you fund it anyway?
4. How much should one new study change your mind? The meta-analysis is based on dozens of experiments across many settings. The new study is one experiment in one setting, but it's the right setting.